

Gold Key Realty

Opening doors through trust, expertise, and commitment.

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2013	200+	5.0★	\$0
Serving NoVA since	Families helped	Client rating	Fees to buyer

Your Home. Your Future.

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From the desk of Ken Stulik

A Letter From Ken

Dear Homebuyer,

Finding the right home is one of the most significant decisions you will ever make — and you deserve a real estate professional who treats it that way. I am Ken Stulik, and my commitment to every client is straightforward: I will be with you at every step of the process, from your first showing to the day you get your keys.

"My job is not simply to find you a house. It is to understand what you need, protect your interests, and deliver results you can count on."

How I work for you

- Comprehensive market analysis and property search
- Expert negotiation to protect your price and terms
- Full oversight of contracts, inspections, and due diligence
- Clear guidance through every stage of the purchase
- Trusted referrals — lenders, inspectors, moving companies
- Neighborhood insight and lifestyle fit assessment

This Buyer Guide outlines exactly how the home purchase process works, answers the questions buyers most commonly ask, and includes the tools to help us identify the neighborhoods and features that matter most to you.

I look forward to earning your trust and finding you the right home.

Sincerely,

Ken Stulik

Licensed Real Estate Professional · Gold Key Realty

Making it official

The Buyer Agency Agreement

The Buyer Agency Agreement formally establishes Ken as your fiduciary — meaning he is legally obligated to act in your best interest at every step. Our version is completely risk-free.

TERM	DETAIL
Retainer fee	Nothing due when you sign. You owe us nothing simply for hiring us.
Cancellation fee	Stop your search at any time, for any reason. No penalties, no questions.
Obligation to buy	None. If you decide not to purchase, you are free to walk away.
At settlement	Our commission is almost always paid 100% by the seller — not by you.
Admin fees	We charge none. Most brokerages charge ~\$500 at closing. We consider those unnecessary.

"Gold Key Realty has never collected a single penny from a buyer. You receive full, top-tier representation — with no upfront costs, no hidden fees, and no obligation to buy."

Step one

Mortgage Pre-Qualification

Before you tour a single home, you need to know what you can afford — and what a lender will approve.

Pre-qualification answers both questions and positions you to move fast when the right property appears.

1 Meet with a loan officer

Share your income, liquid assets, liabilities, and financial details. The lender determines how much they are willing to lend you.

2 Understand your two numbers

The lender gives you two figures: the maximum they will lend, and the monthly payment that comes with it. These are often different from what you are comfortable spending — and that difference matters.

3 Set your real budget

We work back from the monthly payment you are actually comfortable with to establish your true target price range. This keeps your search focused and your finances protected.

4 Get your pre-qualification letter

When you are ready to write an offer, your lender issues a formal pre-qualification letter. No offer can be submitted without one — having this ready gives you a real competitive edge.

Gold Key Realty has built relationships with trusted local lenders across Northern Virginia. If you do not have a lender, we will match you with the right one for your situation — at no cost to you. Our preferred lenders are listed at the back of this guide.

Setting expectations

Factors That Shape Your Search

Every home search is shaped by three factors: Location, Style, and Price. You control two — the market controls the third.

LOCATION

The neighborhood, school district, commute, and community you want.

STYLE

The type, size, layout, and features of the home itself.

PRICE

The market sets this based on your budget and current inventory.

The rule:

You choose two of the three factors. The market determines the third. If you prioritize location and style, the market sets the price. If you fix price and location, the market defines what style of home you can get.

Real-world example

You want to be in Vienna with a budget of \$800K. You have fixed location and price — so the market tells you what style of home you can get: a penthouse condo, a 2,400 sq ft townhome, or a 1,200 sq ft rambler on a quarter acre.

Defining your criteria

Finding Your Perfect Home

A great home search starts with clarity. Before we look at a single listing, we work through three categories of criteria so every property we visit is genuinely worth your time.

LOCATION & NEIGHBORHOOD

- Areas and communities you would enjoy living in
- Proximity to your workplace and commute considerations
- School district preferences
- Nearby shops, restaurants, and conveniences
- Parks, trails, and recreational facilities
- Neighborhood character: established vs. newer development

STRUCTURE & STYLE

- Home type: single family, townhouse, or condo
- Size: small (<2,000 sq ft), medium (2,000–4,000), large (4,000+)
- Architectural style: colonial, split-level, rambler, contemporary
- Bedrooms, bathrooms, and layout configuration
- Yard, outdoor space, and fencing requirements
- Garage, parking, and lot type

PRICE

- Your lender's pre-qualification limit sets your ceiling
- The maximum loan often carries a payment above your comfort — we calibrate to what you can actually spend
- Your pre-qualification ceiling and your real budget are rarely the same number

The full picture

The Homebuying Sequence

- 1 Select a real estate agent**
Your advocate, strategist, and fiduciary throughout the entire process.
- 2 Obtain financial pre-approval**
Know your real budget before you tour a single home.
- 3 Buyer consultation**
Define your needs, timeline, and target areas with Ken.
- 4 Identify and tour properties**
Customized MLS search + showings, with comparative analysis on each property.
- 5 Write and submit an offer**
15-page contract + addenda, EMD, pre-approval letter, optional seller letter.
- 6 Negotiate and ratify**
Counter-offers until all terms are agreed. Ratification locks the home.
- 7 Home inspection**
Licensed inspector reviews the full property. Findings reviewed with Ken.
- 8 Financing & underwriting**
Rate lock, hard credit pull, documentation submission, appraisal.
- 9 Title search**
Settlement attorney clears any liens. Title insurance issued.
- 10 Clear contingencies**
Inspection, financing, and appraisal contingencies resolved.
- 11 Final walk-through**
Verify agreed repairs, seller vacated, home in expected condition.
- 12 Settlement day**
Sign documents, transfer funds, receive keys. You're a homeowner.

Your advocate from day one

What Ken Does For You

Define your search

We establish your target areas, home types, budget, and timeline so every property we look at is worth your time.

Get you pre-qualified

We connect you with the right local lender for your financial situation so you are ready to move when the right home appears.

Find and evaluate properties

Customized property search, tours, and comparable sales analysis so you know exactly what a home is worth before making any decisions.

Write and negotiate your offer

We draft your purchase contract and negotiate on your behalf to secure the best price and terms. In a multiple-offer situation, we position you to win.

Manage inspections and contingencies

We guide you through home inspection, appraisal, and financing contingencies so nothing falls through the cracks on the way to closing.

Support you after closing

Service does not end at settlement. We remain available and will connect you with trusted contractors, movers, and service professionals whenever you need them.

80%+

Repeat & referral clients

\$0

Fees to buyer

100%

Satisfaction standard

Making your move

Breaking Down the Purchase Offer

Once you have found the right home, securing it requires a ratified purchase contract — an agreement where both buyer and seller accept every term. A complete offer has four components.

The Offer Contract Required	Main purchase agreement + addenda. Typically 15 pages plus 1–6 addenda. We review every line with you before you sign.
Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) Typically 1% of purchase price	Signals to the seller that you are serious. Held in escrow and not cashed until after ratification. Protected by your contingencies.
Lender Pre-Approval Letter Required	Confirms to the seller that you are financially qualified to complete the purchase at the offered price.
Letter to the Seller Optional but recommended	When a seller has emotional ties to a home, a personal letter can make a real difference — especially in multiple-offer situations.

After you submit

The Offer Presentation

Once your offer is delivered, one of three things happens. Knowing what to expect from each outcome keeps you in control.

✓ Accepted

Seller accepts outright. You are immediately ratified and move to the contingency phase.

✗ Rejected

Seller rejects outright, ending negotiations. A new offer can be submitted, but leverage is reduced.

■ Counter (~90%)

Seller proposes modified terms. This is the normal path — where skilled negotiation matters most. Both sides exchange counters until all terms are agreed.

"A ratified contract is a major milestone. The home is effectively yours — provided you fulfill the contract terms. Nobody else can take it."

Contract to close

Contingencies — Your Contract Protections

Contingencies are contract clauses that protect you between ratification and settlement. They give you defined rights to inspect, negotiate repairs, verify financing, and exit cleanly if something goes wrong.

HOME INSPECTION CONTINGENCY — TYPICALLY 7 DAYS

Days 1–7	A licensed inspector examines the property — roof, gutters, foundation, HVAC, electrical, plumbing, appliances, attic — and produces a written report.
Review	We review findings and determine what, if anything, to request the seller address. You have the right to ask for repairs or credits at closing.
Negotiate	We negotiate with the seller's side. Whatever they agree to is legally binding — we verify completion at the final walk-through.
Walk-through	At the final walk-through, we confirm all agreed repairs are complete. If they are not, we address it immediately before settlement.

FINANCING CONTINGENCY — PROTECTS YOUR DEPOSIT

Protects you if your loan is not approved after ratification — for example, due to a job loss, credit score change, or other disqualifying event during underwriting. Triggered in roughly 1% of transactions. As long as you have been accurate and forthright with your lender during pre-qualification, this contingency is rarely needed.

Contract to close — continued

The Appraisal Contingency

The appraisal contingency confirms the home is worth what you are paying for it — in the lender's eyes. It is separate from your financing contingency.

Order	After ratification, the lender sends an independent appraiser to assess the property's market value. This is a valuation, not an inspection.
Timeline	The appraised value is delivered within 21 days. In most cases it confirms the purchase price and you proceed without issue.
At or above	If the appraised value meets or exceeds your purchase price — no problem. You proceed to closing.
Below price	If the appraisal comes in low, negotiation begins. The listing agent may challenge the appraisal. If it cannot be challenged, four outcomes are possible.

If the appraisal cannot be challenged — 4 possible outcomes:

- Seller drops the price to appraised value
- Buyer covers the gap out of pocket
- Both parties meet in the middle at a negotiated price
- Buyer exercises the appraisal contingency to exit and recover the full EMD

"We will never waive the appraisal contingency unless there is a clear strategic reason and a solid plan in place. Your financial protection always comes first."

From ratification to settlement

Funding Your Purchase

Once your contract is ratified, the mortgage process moves quickly. Here is every step between ratification and the funds hitting the closing table.

1 Rate lock & formal application

Lock your interest rate immediately after ratification — guaranteeing the rate you were quoted even if rates rise before closing.

2 Underwriting

Your loan package goes to the underwriter. A hard credit pull is conducted and you provide employment verification, bank statements, and asset confirmation.

3 Appraisal

The lender orders an independent appraisal to confirm the collateral value of the home before funding — regardless of whether you have an appraisal contingency.

4 Title search

The settlement attorney conducts a full title search. Any liens are cleared by the seller. Title insurance is issued for both lender and buyer.

5 Loan approval

You are notified of the decision. If approved, loan documents and settlement statement are sent to the title company.

6 Homeowner's insurance

Arrange a homeowner's insurance policy effective from the settlement date. Lenders require proof of coverage before funding.

7 Funding

The lender's closing department reviews the final loan package and transfers funds by wire in time for settlement. You are ready to close.

Know before you close

Closing Costs

Closing costs are separate from your down payment. You will receive a Good Faith Estimate early in the process and a final Settlement Statement (ALTA) a few days before closing.

2.25–4%

Typical range of purchase price

~3%

Average — plan around this

~\$24K

On an \$800,000 purchase

LENDER & LOAN FEES

- Loan origination fee
- Loan processing fees
- Underwriting fees
- Credit report
- Lender's title insurance premium
- Closing protection letter

TITLE, SETTLEMENT & GOVERNMENT FEES

- Title search
- Buyer's title insurance premium
- Settlement fee
- Recording fees
- State/county recordation taxes
- State/county transfer taxes

PREPAIDS & PRORATIONS

- Homeowner's insurance (escrow)
- County tax prorations
- HOA/condo association dues
- Survey (if required)

Your lender provides estimates, and the settlement company works closely with you in the days before closing to confirm every figure. No surprises at the table.

The final stretch

Pre-Closing Checklist

FINAL WALK-THROUGH

Typically the morning of settlement, or one to two days prior, we walk the property together to confirm the seller has vacated and the home is in substantially the same condition as when you last saw it. This is not a new inspection — we are verifying agreed repairs were completed and nothing new has broken or been removed. We check appliances, heating, cooling, and all conveyances. If something is wrong, we address it before you sign — not after.

FINAL SETTLEMENT STATEMENT (ALTA)

One to two days before settlement, your lender and the settlement company send your final ALTA statement — a complete breakdown of every debit and credit for both buyer and seller. The key figure is your **Cash to Close**: your down payment plus closing costs, minus your EMD already on deposit.

Cash to Close must be in the form of a cashier's check, certified check, or wired directly to the settlement company. Personal checks are not accepted.

■ WIRE FRAUD ALERT — READ THIS CAREFULLY

Wire fraud targeting homebuyers is on the rise and financially devastating. Criminals intercept email communications and send convincing fake wiring instructions. **Never wire funds based solely on an email.** Before any wire transfer, call the settlement attorney directly using a phone number you have independently verified — not one from an email. If something feels off, stop and call Ken immediately.

The finish line

Settlement Day

WHAT HAPPENS AT SETTLEMENT

You sit with the settlement attorney to review and sign all loan documents, legal documents, and the deed transfer. Plan for up to one hour. All signatories must be present. Alternatives include remote digital signing, signing by notary, or granting a Power of Attorney (POA) to another party.

WHAT TO BRING

Government-issued photo ID

Driver's license or passport — all signatories must bring one.

Cash to close

Cashier's check, certified check, or confirmed wire transfer.

Checkbook

For handling any minor last-minute adjustments to the final figures.

Your phone

For last-minute communications or digital document access.

Congratulations — You're a Homeowner.

Once everything is signed and funds are confirmed, your agent hands you the keys. It has been a privilege to guide you here — and we are still here for whatever you need next.

Trusted resources

Preferred Lending Partners

If you already have a lender you trust, stay with them. If not, the loan officers below are partners we have worked with extensively. They offer competitive rates, strong loan programs, and the reliability that matters when timelines are tight.

SP

Sandra Potterfield

Intercoastal Mortgage Company

Mobile: 703.587.0498 · **Email:** sandrap@icmtg.com · **Web:** sandrapotterfield.com**Address:** 4100 Monument Corner Dr, Ste 220, Fairfax VA

KO

Kevin O'Connor

Truist Mortgage

Office: 703.444.6402 · **Mobile:** 703.728.6129 · **Email:** kevin.oconnor@truist.com**Address:** 46175 Westlake Dr, Ste 350, Sterling VA · **NMLSR#:** 460639

JJ

Jeremy Johnson

Atlantic Coast Mortgage

Mobile: 571.259.9903 · **Email:** jeremyjohnson@acmlc.com · **Web:** jeremyjohnson.info**Address:** 12700 Fair Lakes Cir, Ste 120, Fairfax VA

Above and beyond

Trusted Service Professionals

Our commitment does not end at closing. Every professional below has been personally vetted by Ken. These are the people we call for our own homes.

REAL ESTATE ATTORNEY

Jessica Youngs

Youngs Law PLLC

■ (703) 346-7001

✉ jessica@federaltitle.com

TITLE & SETTLEMENT

Federal Title & Escrow Co.

■ 202-362-1500

■ federaltitle.com

PAINTER

Carlos Sigala

e-Paint Solutions

■ (571) 471-7820

LANDSCAPING

Luis Portillo

Portillo Landscaping

■ (571) 340-6509

FLOORING

Louis Beaulieu

Beaulieu Flooring

■ (703) 658-8715

✉ louis@beaulieufloors.com

CARPET CLEANING

Luis Luna

Luna Red Carpet Service

■ (571) 259-6012

✉ lunaredcarpet@gmail.com

HANDYMAN

Harry Hardy

One Step Ahead Services

■ (703) 307-1839

✉ hhardylee@yahoo.com

MOVERS

Josh DeVaugh

My Guys Moving

■ (703) 297-2070

■ myguysmoving.com

Gold Key Realty has no financial relationship with any vendor listed above. All referrals are based solely on personal experience and professional trust.